

Salary Negotiation Scripts: Word-for-Word for Every Situation

RenWork Digital Products

Responding to an Initial Job Offer

****Opening Line:**** "Thank you so much for sharing this offer. I am genuinely excited about the role and the team, and I appreciate the transparency you've shown throughout the process."

****The Pivot:**** "Before I formally accept, I want to ensure our expectations are perfectly aligned regarding the compensation package. Based on my research into the market rate for this specific scope of responsibility, as well as the value I will bring to [Specific Company Goal or Project], I believe the current figure is slightly below the range for this position."

****The Ask:**** "Would you be open to adjusting the base salary to [Specific Dollar Amount]? I am confident that if we can bridge this gap, I can sign the offer immediately."

****Objection Handling 1:** "We have a strict budget cap." ******

"I completely understand the need to stay within budget. However, given the immediate impact I can

make on [Specific Project], is there flexibility to structure this as a higher base salary with a performance-based bonus, or perhaps a sign-on bonus to bridge the gap for the first year?"

****Objection Handling 2:** "We need to go back to HR to check." ******

"Absolutely, I respect that process. To help make that conversation easier for you with HR, I've prepared a brief summary of comparable market data for similar roles in our industry. Can I send that over now so you have it handy?"

Counter-Offering Without Sounding Greedy

****Opening Line:**** "I've reviewed the details thoroughly, and I am eager to join. My hesitation stems

solely from ensuring the compensation reflects the full scope of the seniority required for this role."

****The Pivot:**** "I see that the initial offer was [Amount A]. My goal is to reach a number that feels fair and sustainable for both of us, so I don't have to revisit this conversation in six months. Based on my last two years of performance, where I [Specific Achievement], I am looking for a number closer to [Amount B]."

****The Ask:**** "If we can agree on [Amount B], I am ready to move forward with the paperwork today.
Does that work for you?"

****Objection Handling 1:** "That number is above our band for this level."
"I understand the internal bands. Perhaps we can look at this as a hybrid approach? For example, could we start at [Midpoint Amount] with a guaranteed review in three months, contingent on my onboarding and initial impact? This would align with your band structure while acknowledging my experience."

****Objection Handling 2:** "We can't match that number."
"I appreciate your honesty. If the base salary is limited, are there other components we can enhance? For instance, additional PTO days, a remote work stipend, or professional development budget might help balance the overall package for me."

Asking for a Raise Mid-Year

****Opening Line:**** "Hi [Manager's Name], do you have ten minutes this week? I'd love to catch up on my recent projects and discuss my career trajectory here."

****The Pivot:**** "As you know, since joining, I've taken on [Specific New Responsibility] and successfully led [Specific Project], which resulted in [Quantifiable Result, e.g., 15% increase in efficiency]. I've consistently exceeded my KPIs this quarter, specifically [Metric]."

****The Ask:**** "Given this expanded scope and proven results, I would like to discuss adjusting my compensation to [Specific Percentage Increase or Dollar Amount]. I am fully committed to [Company Name] and want to ensure my compensation reflects the value I am currently delivering."

****Objection Handling 1:** "The budget is frozen for this cycle."
"I understand the company-wide constraints. Is it possible to structure this as a one-time bonus rather than a permanent base increase? Or, can we schedule a formal review for the start of the next

fiscal quarter with the goal of hitting [Target Amount] at that time?"

****Objection Handling 2:** "Let's wait until the annual review."**

"I'm willing to wait for the formal review, but I'd like to set a clear expectation now. Can we agree that if I achieve [Specific Goal] by the next review, my salary will be adjusted to [Target Amount]? I'd like to have that target mapped out in our next one-on-one."

Negotiating Freelance Project Rates

****Opening Line:**** "Thanks for sending over the brief. I've reviewed the scope, and I'm very interested in the creative direction you're aiming for."

****The Pivot:**** "To give you an accurate quote, I need to account for the specific deliverables listed, including [Deliverable 1] and [Deliverable 2]. My standard rate for this type of work, which includes two rounds of revisions and full commercial rights, is \$[Rate] per hour or \$[Project Total] fixed fee."

****The Ask:**** "If the scope remains as outlined in the brief, I can start on [Date]. If you have a specific budget in mind that is different from my standard rate, please let me know, and I can look at adjusting the scope to fit that budget."

****Objection Handling 1:** "That's higher than our budget."**

"I understand. My rate reflects the expertise and turnaround time I provide. If the budget is fixed, we could potentially reduce the number of revision rounds or simplify [Specific Deliverable]. Would that be a viable option for you?"

****Objection Handling 2:** "We usually pay less for new clients."**

"I appreciate the offer to start. However, my rates are consistent to ensure I can dedicate the same level of quality and attention to every project. I am happy to offer a 50% deposit upfront to secure my calendar, which also helps with cash flow for both parties."

Asking for Equity

****Opening Line:**** "I'm incredibly proud of what we've built this year, particularly [Milestone]. I'm looking to align my long-term incentives more closely with the company's success."

****The Pivot:**** "While I value my current cash compensation, I see significant potential in [Company

Name]'s growth trajectory. I believe having a stake in the equity would demonstrate my long-term commitment and align my interests with the investors and leadership."

****The Ask:**** "I would like to request a grant of [Number] options or shares, with a standard four-year vesting schedule and a one-year cliff. How does the current cap table look regarding additional grants for key team members?"

****Objection Handling 1:** "We don't have room in the pool right now."*

"I understand the pool is finite. Could we discuss a future-dated grant tied to a specific milestone or the next funding round? I am happy to sign a term sheet now that outlines the amount, valid upon the next equity refresh."

****Objection Handling 2:** "Equity is only for executives."*

"I respect the current policy. However, given my role in [Critical Function], I would argue that my contribution directly impacts revenue. Could we pilot a smaller grant for me as a key non-executive contributor, with the understanding that this can be revisited as the company scales?"

Negotiating Benefits and PTO

****Opening Line:**** "I'm really happy with the base salary offer. I do have a few questions about the benefits package to ensure it meets my personal needs."

****The Pivot:**** "I noticed the standard PTO is [Number] days. Given the high-intensity nature of this role, I find that [Higher Number] days allows me to maintain peak performance without burnout. I also value [Specific Benefit, e.g., Health Stipend or 401k Match]."

****The Ask:**** "Could we adjust the PTO to [Higher Number] days? Alternatively, if the PTO is fixed, would you be open to adding a [Specific Benefit, e.g., \$500/month wellness stipend] to the package?"

****Objection Handling 1:** "PTO is uniform across the department."*

"I understand the need for consistency. Is there flexibility to allow me to bank unused PTO or take a longer continuous block of time off during the low season? Or, could we add a 'sabbatical' option after three years of service?"

****Objection Handling 2:** "We can't change the benefits structure."******

"That's fair. If the benefits are locked in, is there any flexibility in the start date? I am currently in the middle of a personal commitment. If you can offer a two-week delay in the start date, I can accept the current benefits package as is."

Handling 'That Is Our Final Offer'

****Opening Line:**** "I appreciate your transparency. I want to be clear that I am very interested in this role and don't want to leave the door open for misunderstanding."

****The Pivot:**** "I understand that this is the final number you can offer. I value the opportunity to work with this team, and I am prepared to accept this offer. However, I want to make sure we are both comfortable with this being the final figure to avoid any future friction."

****The Ask:**** "If I accept this offer today, can we document a mutual understanding that my performance and the market conditions will be the primary drivers for my next compensation review in

12 months? I want to ensure that accepting this 'final' number doesn't cap my future growth."

****Objection Handling 1:**